



MINDFULNESS ON THE MATS

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Counterstrike Leadership Program

Instructor Guide

Children & Teens · Ages 7–16 · 6 Modules + Graduation

Developing black-belt character inside and outside the dojo.

COUNTERSTRIKE LEADERSHIP PROGRAM — INSTRUCTOR GUIDE

Program Overview & Mission

Mission: To develop black-belt character inside and outside the dojo. The Counterstrike Leadership Program equips students with the tools to regulate their emotions, communicate effectively, and lead with integrity.

Program Detail	Specification
Target Audience	Children & Teens (Ages 7–16)
Format	6 Modules (1.5 Hours each) + Graduation
Total Duration	9–10 Hours of Curriculum

■ **IMPORTANT DISCLAIMER**

This is NOT therapy. This program is designed for skills training and leadership development. It does not replace professional mental health counseling.



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MODULE 1 OF 6 · Coping Skills

Module 1: The Internal Guard

Focus: Emotion Regulation & Grounding

1. Introduction: The "Internal Guard"

PROBLEM STATEMENT

- Explain that just as we have a physical guard to protect our bodies, we need an "Internal Guard" to protect our minds from stress, anger, or anxiety.
- *Activity:* Ask students what "lowering your guard" looks like emotionally (yelling, crying, freezing up). Creates awareness around dysregulation — you can't consciously stop something you're not aware of.

TOOLS / ANSWERS

2. The Ice Plunge (The "Reset" Button)

- **Concept:** Cold water triggers the "Mammalian Dive Reflex," which instantly slows the heart rate.
- **Drill:** Have a bowl of cold water (or ice packs). Students splash cold water on their faces or hold an ice pack to their cheeks. Cold towel on the back of the neck.

3. Breathing Techniques (The "Recovery" Breath)

- **Diaphragmatic Breathing:** Teach "Belly Breathing." Place a hand on the belly; it should rise like a balloon.
- **Body Scan:** Close eyes, squeeze/release muscles from toes to head.
- **The 5 Senses Drill:** Name 5 things you see, 4 feel, 3 hear, 2 smell, 1 taste.

[WORKSHEET 1] — My Mental Armor

Name: _____

THE SITUATION

Think of a time this week you felt angry, scared, or nervous.

• **What happened?** _____

• How did your body feel? (Circle one): Hot | Shaky | Tense | Fast Heartbeat

Other: _____

MY REGULATION TOOLS

Check off the techniques you will try next time your "Internal Guard" drops:

■ **The Ice Reset:** Splash cold water on face.

■ **Belly Breathing:** 4 seconds in, 4 seconds hold, 4 seconds out.

■ **5-4-3-2-1 Grounding:**

5 Things I see: _____

4 Things I feel: _____

3 Things I hear: _____

2 Things I smell: _____

1 Thing I taste: _____

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MODULE 2 OF 6 · Social Skills

Module 2: Verbal Judo

Focus: Communication & Conflict Resolution

1. The Stance of a Leader

- **Body Posture:** Shoulders back, chin up. A leader looks ready, not defeated.
- **Eye Contact:** In conversation, the “target” is the other person’s eyes.
- **Voice Control:** Not a whisper, not a scream — use a “Command Voice”: firm and clear.

2. The DEESC Script (Verbal Self-Defense)

Teach the acronym for resolving conflict without fighting:

Letter	Stands For	Description
D	Describe	What happened? (Just the facts)
E	Express	How did it make you feel?
E	Empathize	Acknowledge the other person’s perspective.
S	Specify	What do you want to change?
C	Consequences	Positive outcome if resolved; protective if not

[WORKSHEET 2] — The DEESC Defense

Objective: Use your words to block a conflict and counter with a solution.

SCENARIO: *A teammate keeps cutting in front of you during line drills.*

1. DESCRIBE (The Facts) — Don't attack. Just say what happened.

Example: "I noticed that you stepped in front of me three times in line today."

D: _____

2. EXPRESS (The Feeling) — Use "I" statements.

Example: "I feel frustrated because I am waiting for my turn."

E: _____

3. EMPATHIZE (The Other Side) — Acknowledge their perspective.

Example: "I know you might not have realized you were doing it."

E: _____

4. SPECIFY (The Solution) — What do you want them to do?

Example: "I would like you to please go to the back of the line."

S: _____

5. CONSEQUENCES (The Outcome) — Why is this good for the team?

Example: "If we all wait our turn, Sensei won't have to stop class to correct us."

C: _____

MODULE 3 OF 6 · Leadership Skills

Module 3: Leading the Rank

Focus: Public Speaking & Feedback

1. Command Presence (Public Speaking)

- **Tips:** Plant your feet (no swaying), project to the back wall, pause for emphasis. Re-introduce belly breathing from Module 1 for grounding.
- **Drill:** Students introduce themselves and their favorite move using "Command Presence."

2. The Feedback Sandwich (The "Sensei Sandwich")

Teach how to correct others without discouraging them:

Layer	Element	Description
Top Bun	Praise	Something they did well.
Meat	Correction	What to fix — specific and clear.
Bottom Bun	Praise	Encouragement to end on a high note.

3. Modeling Behavior

- "You are always on stage." Lower ranks are watching how you tie your belt, how you sit, and how you treat your parents.

[WORKSHEET 3] — The Sensei Sandwich

Mission: You are helping a White Belt fix their punch. They punch hard but their hands are dropping down.

1. TOP BUN (Praise) — Find one thing they are doing awesome at.

Example: "Your power is incredible!"

Your turn: _____

2. THE MEAT (The Fix) — Tell them exactly what to improve.

Example: "Keep your hands up by your cheeks so you don't get hit."

Your turn: _____

3. BOTTOM BUN (Praise) — End on a high note.

Example: "Keep that up and you'll be unstoppable."

Your turn: _____



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MODULE 4 OF 6 · Decision Making

Module 4: The Moral Compass

Focus: Values & Choices

1. Values: Your Internal Compass

- When lost in the woods, a compass points North. When unsure what to do in life, your **Values** point the way.
- *Note:* These can overlap with parents/school, but must be *yours*.

2. Pros & Cons Analysis

- Teaches logical decision making.
- *Drill:* "Should I quit the team?" — List pros and cons on a whiteboard.

3. One-Word Values

- Identify core "One-Word" identities (e.g., "Brave," "Kind," "Loyal").



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[WORKSHEET 4] — My Black Belt Values**Step 1: Circle Your Top 5 Values****Values — Circle Your Top 5**

Adventurous · Honest · Hardworking · Kind · Strong

Creative · Loyal · Fun · Respectful · Brave

Step 2: The Compass Check**My #1 Value:** _____**Scenario:** You see a kid being bullied at school.**If I follow my value, I would:**

If I ignore my value, I would:

Step 3: Pros and Cons — Decision: *Should I stay up late gaming the night before a tournament?*

PROS (Good stuff)	CONS (Bad stuff)
1. Fun time now	1. Will be tired tomorrow
2. _____	2. Might lose my match
3. _____	3. _____

MODULE 5 OF 6 · Organization

Module 5: Mission Planning

Focus: Goals & Accountability

1. S.M.A.R.T. Goals

"I want to get better" is a bad goal. "I want to do 10 push-ups by Friday" is a SMART goal.

Letter	Stands For	What It Means
S	Specific	Exactly what will you do?
M	Measurable	How many? How often? How long?
A	Attainable	Can you actually achieve this?
R	Relevant	Does this move you toward your Black Belt goals?
T	Time-bound	When is the deadline?

2. The Accountability Team

- **Asking for Help:** It is not weakness; it is strategy.
- **Body Doubling:** Having someone sit with you while you work (even silently) helps you focus.
- **Accountability:** Tell a friend your goal so they can check in with you.

[WORKSHEET 5] — Mission: SMART Goal

My Goal: _____

MAKE IT SMART:

- **Specific:** What exactly will you do? _____
- **Measurable:** How many? How long? _____
- **Attainable:** Can you actually do this? ■ Yes ■ No
- **Relevant:** Does this help you become a Black Belt leader? _____
- **Time-bound:** Deadline: _____

MY ACCOUNTABILITY PARTNER:

Who will I tell about this goal?

When will they check on me?



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MODULE 6 OF 6 · Confidence

Module 6: The Champion's Mindset

Focus: Self-Talk & Vision

1. Notice the "Opponent" Inside

- Discuss "Negative Self-Talk" — the voice that says "I can't" or "I suck." Flag absolutes: "Never" and "Always" are red flags.
- *Drill:* Catch the thought. Stop it. Correct it.

2. Flipping the Script (Self-Compassion)

- Treat yourself like a teammate. You wouldn't tell a teammate "You're stupid" if they missed a kick. Don't say it to yourself either.

3. Vision Board

- **Assignment:** Students cut out pictures or draw images of who they want to be as a Black Belt Leader.



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[WORKSHEET 6] — Flipping the Script

Instructions: Imagine your brain is a dojo. Negative thoughts are intruders. Block them and counter with a Positive Strike.

THE ATTACK (Negative Thought)	THE BLOCK & COUNTER (Positive Self-Talk)
"I'm terrible at this form. I'll never get it."	"I am still learning. If I practice, I will improve."
"Everyone is looking at me because I messed up."	"Mistakes happen. I am brave for trying."
"I am too scared to lead the class."	_____

"I'm not strong enough."	_____



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GRADUATION · 1.5 Hour Ceremony

Graduation: The Black Belt Leader

1. The Recital

- Students dress formally (Suit/Tie or Full Uniform).
- Each student presents one skill they learned (e.g., demonstrates the Feedback Sandwich or recites their Mission Statement).
- Presentation of vision boards.

2. The Ceremony

- Award the **"Certificate of Completion"** for the Counterstrike Leadership Program.

Final Words: Leadership is not a rank; it is a habit.

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